

It was a survey they undertook as students of a post-graduate course at IIM-A that spurred them to do what most students seldom do after passing out from its portals. Rejecting jobs which were paying them Rs 18 lakh a year, Nikhil Vaswani, 28, and Rohit Shankar, 25, decided to turn entrepreneurs, setting up a chain of wellness centres with an initial bank loan of Rs 10 lakh.

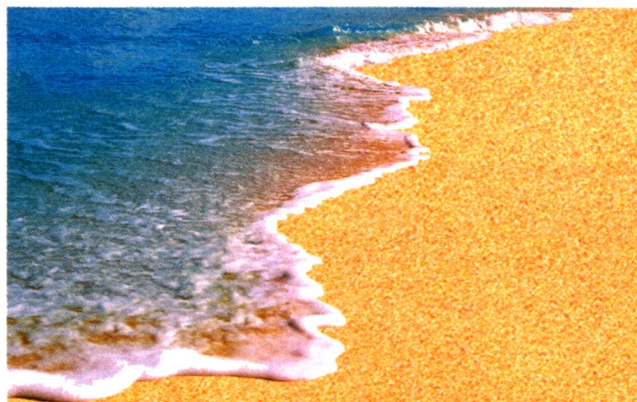
Delving deeper into the Ahmedabad scene, they realised the city of five million had only a few good fitness centres, leave aside wellness centres. After passing out in 2006, they set up a small fitness centre in Gandhinagar to cater to government employees. Once they had learnt the ropes they decided to go in for a full-fledged wellness centre in Ahmedabad, complete with the most-accomplished trainers, top-class equipment and a spa facility, which was not an easy task. They scoured the city for an investment partner, travelling across on their two-wheeler in the city's scorching heat. Having found a willing partner in T.S. Anand of Sirisha Infrastructure, Shankar and Vaswani set up Wellocity, a wellness centre, at an investment of Rs 2.5 crore. Each of the 20 trainers at the gym is secretly evaluated by the customers on a periodic basis. Another software allows the clients' progress to be evaluated. In its first year, the centre has a turnover of over Rs 1.5 crore and a membership of 700. Vaswani says the two of them are "determined to set new standards in the wellness business". Looks quite likely.

by Uday Mahurkar

to follow in the footsteps of her parents, who are doctors. Instead, she wanted to start a company, which would have the rural sector and technology as its key elements. To achieve her dreams, she invested all her savings in a nascent project, which got registered as DesiCrew in 2007. While the easy part of the business was to identify locations, the more difficult one was to convince clients that BPO units in rural areas could deliver the same quality of service. With five BPO centres and several blue-chip clients, the company, specialising in document management and data digitisation, employs 105 people in the state.

Given that the first three years in any enterprise are very tough, Malhotra survives on a basic income and lives in district guest houses while travelling. What has worked for her is the strength and support she derives from her parents. Some of Malhotra's friends too have joined DesiCrew after seeing the rapid growth of her company. Her friends are fellow entrepreneurs who are trying to make a success of their ventures. Like all single girls her age, Malhotra too does all that people of her generation do—watch movies and hang out with friends, all of whom she smilingly says are "gainfully employed".

by Malini Bhupta



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